

Report Says Denver Out As Yankee Farm

Cont'd. from First Sports Page

Paso, Texas, by the Rocky Mountain News, Cohen seemed to confirm at least the fact he had been fired.

"That's the way it goes in baseball," Cohen said. "I enjoyed the experience."

Howsam began operation of a Denver team in the Class A Western League in 1946 and moved to the American Association following the shift of the Athletics. The Rocky Mountain News said Howsam paid the Yankees \$75,000 for the Kansas City franchise to enter the American Association in '55.

With the \$75,000 went a Yankee working agreement that paid Howsam good results on the field and even handsomer results at the box office. The Bears finished third in '55 and second in '56 and '57 and each year Denver was near the top in minor league attendance. In '57 the Bears won the American Association playoffs and beat Buffalo in the Little World Series.

Houk Was Manager

Ralph Houk was Denver's manager the Bears' first three seasons as a Yankee farm. He was promoted to Casey Stengel's Stadium coaching staff following his Little World Series victory and Cohen, not a Yankee man, was named Denver manager by Howsam.

Vees' Record

With a limited Yankee pact in '56 the Virginians finished fifth. They moved up to third in '57 with a full working agreement but tailed off to sixth this season with a team that was beset by injuries. Ed Lopat managed the Vees the past three seasons but at the end of the present campaign he indicated he did not expect to return.

If the Denver story is true it could turn out to be the best baseball news for Richmond since the city returned to the International League in 1954. If the Virginians did turn out to be the No. 1—or only—Yankee Triple-A farm they would be almost certain to be an important factor in the IL race.

Most observers felt last season that if the Vees and Bears could have combined the resulting team would have been a pennant winner in either the IL or AA. Denver started fast but faded because of lack of pitching, while the Vees, because of injuries, never were a factor. The Bears had most of the Yankees' older Triple-A players, most of whom are expected to be in the minors again next year. The Vees had the younger ones and at season's end speculation was that such as Deron Johnson, Cletis Boyer, Jim Bronstad and Ed Dick would be allowed to mature in the minors another year.